

Bad Girl Gospel: The Story of Noa

A Confession About the Name She Had to Survive

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First paperback edition, 2026

Fiction Note

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, conversations, and events in this book are products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, or to real events is purely coincidental. This story engages themes of name, identity, faith, shame, survival, family, desire, and social judgment. It is not written to turn a life into spectacle, but to trace the cost of being misread and the courage required to live truthfully.

Author's Note

Bad Girl Gospel began as a way of listening to women the world had already named before it ever understood them. This series is not interested in clean heroines or simple villains. It is interested in women who have been judged, reduced, desired, rejected, moralised over, and spoken about more often than they have been truly heard. Noa belongs to that world. She is not written as a revelation, a trick, or a surprise. She is written as a woman.

And as a survivor. This book does not ask the reader to be shocked by Noa. It asks the reader to stay long enough to understand what she had to survive: a name, a body under scrutiny, a faith shaped by fear, a family wounded by what it could not understand, and a world that can punish people for refusing to keep living inside a lie. Noa's story is not a manual of transition. It is not an argument dressed as fiction. It is a confession about the cost of becoming visible when invisibility was the price of being accepted. If Selah was about the body and Diana was about vows, Noa is about the name.

The name given. The name refused. The name weaponized. The name chosen. The name survived. At its core, Bad Girl Gospel is still the same confession: The so-called "bad girl" is often just the woman who stopped making herself easy for other people's stories.

Opening Manifesto

A Confession About the Name She Had to Survive

My name is Noa.

That was not always
the name they used
when they talked about me.

But it was always
the name my bones knew.

To some people,
I am a warning.

Don't end up like her.
Don't become strange.
Don't ruin a perfectly good life.
Don't trade a respectable story
for whatever this is.

They call me many things.

Cold.
Difficult.
Confusing.
A phase.
A fraud.
A problem.

Bad girl.

They say it like a verdict.

Like one label
can explain everything
they never cared enough
to understand.

It is easier that way.

Bad girl is simpler
than saying:

woman with a history
you never had to carry,

body
you never had to survive,

name
you never had to escape.

Here is the part
they rarely ask about:

I did not wake up one day
and decide to burn
my old life down
for drama.

I woke up,
day after day,
inside a name
that was killing me slowly

and called it obedience.

I knew how to perform
what they called
a good son.

A good boy.
A good brother.
A good member.
A good example.

I knew how to answer
to a name
that made everyone else comfortable,

even as it made me disappear.

They clapped
for that version of me.

They called that version
faithful.
Humble.
Stable.
Promising.

They never saw
the way my hands trembled
when someone shouted that name
across a room

and every cell in my body
felt mispronounced.

There is a word
for the name
they refuse to bury.

Deadname.

It sounds dramatic
until you realise
some of us had to let
something die

before we could stay alive.

This book is not about
that old name.

You will not find it here.

Not because it never existed,
but because it already took enough
from the woman I am.

What matters is this:

I had to survive
the person everyone else
insisted I was

before I could become
the person I actually am.

For a long time,
I tried to do both.

Live as their good boy
and my own quiet girl.

Switch costumes
depending on who
was in the room.

In church,
I lowered my voice.

In mirrors,
I raised my eyes.

In family photos,
I stood where they placed me.

In my mind,
I kept stepping
out of the frame.

I prayed.

Of course I prayed.

"God, fix me."

"God, forgive me."

"God, remove this."

"God, make me normal."

No one told me
I was asking Him
to bless a lie.

No one told me
that sometimes
the thing you call faithfulness
is just fear
with better vocabulary.

They called me obedient
as long as I stayed
in the costume.

The day I refused,
obedience turned into rebellion
in their mouths.

They called me a bad girl
because I refused
to keep living
as a good lie.

This gospel was never meant
for the women
who got everything right.

It was meant
for the ones
whose lives are turned
into warnings,

sermons,

gossip,

and lessons

without their consent.

The rumor about me
will always be simpler
than the truth.

Rumor:

She threw her life away
to become someone else.

Truth:

I stopped letting a name
I never chose
become the altar
where everyone else sacrificed
the woman I actually was.

I have been called
many things.

Son.
Brother.
Abomination.
Confusion.
Disappointment.
Phase.
Sin.
Experiment.

Bad girl.

This is my gospel:

A name given in love
can still become a cage.

A body assigned in certainty
can still feel like a house
you were never meant
to live in.

I am not writing this
to make you comfortable.

I am writing this
because I am tired

of hearing my story
only in other people's mouths.

This is not a manifesto
about how everyone should live.

It is a confession
about what I had to leave
in order to stay alive.

I am not asking
to be seen as pure.

I am not asking
to be seen as brave.

I am asking
to be seen as a woman
who survived her own name.

My name is Noa.

I am not innocent.

I am not a mistake.

I am the bad girl
they got
the day I refused
to keep being
their good lie.

Chapter 1

The Rumor

By the time most people met Noa, they had already heard something about her. Not always the same story. Never the whole one.

"Watch out for her." "She's complicated." "She has a past." "She's not what she looks like."

They never explained what that meant. Some said it with disgust. Some said it with fascination. Some said it with the thrill of knowing a secret that was not theirs to tell. Noa walked into rooms where her body arrived last.

Her name arrived first. Not the one on her coffee cup. The one whispered in group chats. Messages forwarded. Stories half-told.

"Do you know about Noa?" "Did you hear?" "Someone told me she used to..."

The sentence rarely finished the same way twice. In some versions, she was a liar. In others, a seductress. In others, a confused soul to be pitied and prayed for. Rumor has a way of stretching itself to fit whatever fear a person carries.

For some, she was a warning about what happens when a woman refuses to stay small. For others, she was a joke about modern times and people who no longer know who they are. For a few, she was a fantasy they would never admit out loud. People looked at her differently depending on which rumor they had chosen to believe. Men looked at her like a dare.

"Women like that are risky," they would say,

eyes not leaving her body.

"Dangerous."

Dangerous often meant: someone I want in private and will condemn in public. Women looked at her like a test case.

"How far is too far?"

"Where does femininity end and deception begin?"

"Is she taking something that is not hers?"

They dissected her clothes. Her makeup. Her posture.

"Too much." "Trying too hard." "Doing the most."

Noa heard it all. Not because they said it to her face. Because spaces leak. Group chats spill into corridors. Corridors spill into pews.

Pews spill into prayer requests. Prayer requests spill into gossip with better language.

"She needs covering." "She needs deliverance." "She needs counselling."

She needed, apparently, everything but consent. The rumor was efficient. It reduced her life to a headline people could repeat without choking on nuance. Bad girl. Problem.

Confusion. Evidence of the times. No one agreed on the details. Some thought she was promiscuous. Some thought she was cold.

Some thought she was faithless. Some thought she was dangerously spiritual. But almost everyone agreed on one thing: Noa was not like other women. They meant it as an accusation.

Sometimes as a fetish. Rarely as an invitation to actually know her. In church, they softened the edges.

"She has a strong personality."

"She struggles with submission."

"She's still working through things."

They nodded with that particular blend of concern and superiority reserved for people who sin in ways others find interesting. Leaders did not always confront her directly. They preached around her. Sermons about order.

About creation. About men in their place and women in theirs. They did not say her name from the pulpit. They did not have to. She had learned long ago how to hear herself between the lines.

Outside church, the rumors adapted. At work, she was intimidating. In cafés, mysterious. Online, she became an idea people debated without ever asking if she wanted to be a topic.

Some days, she wore their projections like armour. Fine. If you insist on seeing me as dangerous, I will learn how to survive being feared. Other days, it stung.

Not because she wanted to be accepted by everyone. Because it reminded her how quickly people will call a woman deceptive for doing nothing more than existing outside the story they wrote for her. The rumor asked simple questions. Is she lying?

Is she normal? Is she allowed? The truth asked harder ones. What happens to a person when the version people remember is treated as more real than the woman standing in front of them?

What happens to a soul when survival looks, from the outside, like rebellion? What happens to a woman when every room she enters demands an explanation before it allows her to simply be? Noa was many things.

Sharp. Guarded. Kind in ways most people never saw. Tired in ways most people never cared to ask about. She had made mistakes.

She had sinned, if that was the language you used. She had lied. She had hidden. But the rumor rarely made room for the reason behind the hiding. It was easier to say,

"She likes attention,"

than to admit that some people hide because exposure has nearly killed them before. By the time the rumor was done with her, the world was certain about Noa. Certain enough to whisper. Certain enough to warn.

Certain enough to turn her life into a lesson without ever asking what it had cost her to survive it. They did not yet know how much of her life had already been spent trying to be good inside a name that never belonged to her.

Chapter 2

Before the Name

Before Noa ever corrected anyone, before she ever said,

“That’s not my name,”

she had already spent a lifetime answering to one. It was a good name, according to everyone else. Strong. Biblical. Masculine enough to make grandparents proud and pastors relaxed.

They chose it carefully. Prayed over it. Wrote it in baby books. Announced it in church. Hung it on nursery walls in wooden letters.

“This is who you are,” they said,

smiling. She believed them. Children do. She learned to write it before she learned how to spell all the words for what she felt. She heard it shouted across playgrounds.

Printed on report cards. Called during roll call. Every time, she answered. Present. Here.

Yes. Her mouth obeyed long after her body started flinching. At home, the name came with expectations.

“Be a man.”

“Stand up straight.”

“Don’t cry like that.”

“Take care of your sister.”

“Your job is to protect.”

She watched how adults treated boys and girls differently. Boys got warnings. Girls got supervision. Boys got boys will be boys. Girls got be careful.

Boys were told to lead. Girls were told to be led. She understood the rules before she understood why they felt wrong. In church, the name sat comfortably inside sermons. Men of God with names like hers were heroes of the faith.

Women with names like the one she would later choose were lessons, supporting characters, footnotes. She was taught where she belonged by where they seated her.

Youth group on one side for the guys. Youth group on the other side for the girls. She went where they pointed. Sat in circles where conversations were about lust, leadership,

responsibility, calling. They talked about being the head of the home. About one day, when you are a husband. About how your wife will need you to stand firm.

She nodded. Took notes. Repeated lines. Inside, another sentence kept forming and dissolving: This doesn't fit.

But fit was not an option she thought she had. Fit was a duty. So she became good at it. She lowered her voice. Learned how to shake hands like she meant business.

Wore the clothes picked for her, even when mirrors felt like they were lying. When people complimented her parents, they would say,

"You raised a good boy."

"So respectful."

"Such a gentleman."

"He'll make a great man of God."

Every blessing felt like a verdict. Every good boy was a reminder that she was doing her job well: disappearing. There were small betrayals she committed against herself before she ever found the word for them.

The way she laughed differently depending on who was around. The way she kept her hands in her pockets so no one would see how they wanted to move. The way she swallowed tears because boys are strong, even when the strongest thing she could have done was cry.

Sometimes, late at night, she would whisper her own name the way she heard it inside. Not the one on certificates. The one that came like a half-remembered song.

It was not always Noa. At first, it was only not what she had. A softer sound. A different cadence.

A name that lived in her throat and refused to come out because everything around her declared it impossible. The first time she wrote it down,

it was in a notebook she hid under a mattress. Just to see if the letters felt right. They did. It terrified her. Names were not neutral in her world.

Names meant role. Role meant obedience. Obedience meant survival. To imagine another name was to imagine another life. Another life meant betraying the one

everyone else had invested in. So she tore the page out. Threw it away. Pretended she had never seen how good it looked. But the body remembers before the mind allows it.

She found herself gravitating toward things that reflected what she could not yet say. Characters in stories. Songs sung by women whose pain sounded familiar in ways that confused her.

She paid attention to how other girls moved through the world. What they were allowed to wear. How they were allowed to cry. The ways they were allowed to express softness without being corrected.

She did not envy their rules. She envied their permission. At the same time, she saw the dangers. How girls were blamed for attention they never asked for. How their bodies were turned into topics.

How their worth was measured in purity and silence. It was not that she thought being a girl would be easier. It was that being a boy felt like a lie. Between those two truths, she chose the one that seemed less damning to everyone around her. Stay.

Be good. Make peace with the name you have.

“God doesn’t make mistakes,” they said often.

She believed that too. She just quietly wondered how much of her torment came from God’s design, and how much came from people’s refusal to imagine He could have made her any other way

than the box they saw. Before the name Noa ever touched her lips, she had already learned what happens when you try to live faithfully inside a name that does not belong to you. You gain applause.

You gain safety. You gain belonging. You lose yourself. It was never only about pronouns or papers. It was about the slow ache of being praised

for a performance that felt like erosion. Before the name, there was the script. Before the confession, there was the good life everyone insisted she should be grateful for. Before Noa, there was a version of her built entirely on what other people needed her to be.

She survived that. Barely. And survival, as she would discover, was not the same thing as being alive.

Chapter 3

The Good Lie

Noa did not become a liar by being careless. She became a liar by being excellent. Excellent student. Excellent son. Excellent young man of God.

People trust excellence. They do not question it. If the grades are high, if the behaviour is clean, if the service is constant, who would suspect that the person at the centre is quietly vanishing? She learned early that the more competent she became,

the fewer questions people asked. So she applied herself. To everything. School. Work.

Church. She carried chairs without being asked. Stayed late to clean. Showed up early to help. Others called it servanthood.

She called it staying too busy to think. When you are constantly in motion, it is easier to avoid mirrors. At home, she became the reliable one.

“Can you pick up your sister?”

“Yes.”

“Can you help your mother?”

“Yes.”

“Can you take your father’s place at this event?”

“Yes.”

She never said no. No would have forced her to admit she had limits. Limits would have forced her to look at the part of herself already exhausted from being someone else's answer. In church, she became a testimony.

“Look what God can do with a young man who submits.”

They loved that word. Submit. It meant do not ask too many questions. It meant trust the structure. It meant deny yourself in ways that make us comfortable,

and we will call it holiness. She did it well. She lifted her hands in worship with the right posture. Prayed out loud with the right tone. Preached short devotionals about surrender with the right verses.

People cried.

“Your faith is so strong.”

“You’re such an example to the younger boys.”

“You’re going to be a great leader one day.”

She smiled. Thanked them. Went home and lay in the dark, wondering why their compliments felt like accusations. If they knew, she thought,

if they knew the things I do not say, would they still call me faithful? The good lie was not that she pretended to love God. She did love God. The lie was that she pretended God wanted her disappearance.

There is a kind of obedience that looks beautiful from the outside and feels like a slow death within. She entered that like a calling. Every time she felt a crack,

she covered it with more discipline. Read more. Pray more. Serve more. Confess safer sins.

“I struggle with pride.”

“I struggle with anger.”

“I struggle with control.”

Confessions people could applaud. Confessions that did not touch the foundation. The foundation was this: I am not who they think I am. To say that out loud felt like betrayal.

Of her parents. Of her pastors. Of God. So she learned to become the best version of their expectations.

The good lie was tidy. People could point to it at conferences.

“Look at him.”

“He kept himself pure.”

“He stayed in church.”

“He didn’t go wild.”

They did not see the places where she was already wild in her own head. Not in the ways their sermons warned about. Not sex. Not drugs.

Not rebellion with tattoos and neon lights. Wild like a trapped animal pacing inside its cage. Testing the bars. Testing the lock. Testing how long it could keep walking in circles

before collapsing. She started writing letters she never sent. To God. To herself. Sometimes to a future person who might one day understand.

“I am trying,” she wrote.

“Please do not hate me if I cannot carry this forever.”

No one saw those letters. Publicly, she doubled down. Volunteered for mission trips. Hosted Bible studies. Sat with younger kids and told them

God loves them exactly as they are. The irony was not lost on her. She could articulate grace for everyone else better than she could accept it for herself. It is easier to preach freedom

than to risk it. The good lie was rewarded. Invitations. Positions. Trust.

People handed her microphones, keys, and titles. Assistant leader. Coordinator.

Right hand. Every new role was another layer between her and the truth. If she ever broke, it would not only be her life. It would shake the image of every person who had used her story

as evidence that their system worked. That thought alone kept her in place longer than fear. Responsibility can be another word for chain. There were moments, tiny ones, where the lie slipped.

A laugh too unguarded with women who felt like home. A softness in her voice that she forgot to flatten around certain people. A way she looked at herself in a window reflection and saw,

for a second, the outline of the woman she really was. She always corrected quickly. Joke. Deflection.

Overcompensation. The good lie relied on speed. Correct yourself before anyone asks why. She became so good at it that even her body joined the performance.

Heart slowing under scrutiny. Breath smoothing when called by the old name. Shoulders squaring when someone said,

“You’re such a solid man.”

Inside, a small part of her kept screaming. You’re lying. The scream never made it to her mouth. She shut it down with verses. Deny yourself.

Crucify the flesh. Take up your cross daily. No one had told her that your cross is not supposed to be your own existence. No one had told her there is a line

between holy sacrifice and self-erasure. The good lie blurred that line. Every compliment she received for being disciplined, helpful,

humble, available, was another reason to keep the truth quiet.

“Why ruin this?” a voice in her asked.

“Why disappoint them?”

“Why risk becoming exactly the kind of story

they warn other people about?” So she stayed. Longer than she should have. Better than she needed to. Until the day came when the lie,

no matter how good, could no longer hold the weight of the woman it was crushing.

Chapter 4

The Mirror

The mirror was never neutral. It was a battlefield where everyone else's words collided with what Noa's body had been trying to say for years. Most days, she avoided it. Get dressed quickly. Brush teeth.

Glance only at what was necessary. Enough to pass. Not enough to notice. But there were nights when the house was quiet, when the weight of the day had nowhere else to go,

and the mirror became impossible to ignore. She would stand there, door closed, light a little too bright, and look.

Really look. At the jaw she had been told to be proud of. At the shoulders people said were strong. At the hands that had carried chairs, Bibles,

and other people's expectations. On paper, this was a success story. A solid man. A young man of God. An excellent son.

In glass, it was a stranger. She tried to see what everyone else celebrated. Tilted her head. Adjusted posture. Practised the expressions she had been praised for.

The serious one. The humble one. The confident one. They all felt borrowed. The mirror did not argue.

That was what made it cruel. It only reflected. Hair. Skin. Angles.

A life that looked correct and felt uninhabitable. No one had prepared her for the day when standing there would feel like an act of betrayal.

Because every time she looked, the question rose: Who are you when no one is here to clap for the act? She remembered being a child, playing dress-up in clothes too big,

laughing at the way fabric swallowed her frame. Back then, everyone knew it was pretend. Now, the clothes fitted. The pretending did not. She caught herself squinting.

If she stared long enough, could she see the outline of the woman she felt like inside? Sometimes, in the tilt of a shoulder, in the softness of her mouth when she forgot to harden it,

in the way her eyes changed when she allowed herself one second of tenderness toward her own reflection, she saw her. Briefly.

Like a figure behind glass, standing just out of frame. Those moments were both mercy and torment. Mercy, because they reminded her she was not crazy.

Torment, because they reminded her how far her life still was from that image. She tried bargaining.

“If I can just stay like this

and be grateful, maybe the ache will shrink.”

“If I can marry,

if I can be a good husband, a good father, a good leader, maybe this feeling will eventually stop.” She had been taught to distrust feelings.

Feelings lie, they said. Truth is what God says, not what you feel. But what do you do when you are no longer sure if what people shouted over your life in God’s name was ever the same as God’s voice?

The mirror did not answer. It only reflected. On some nights, she pressed her hands flat against the sink and whispered,

“Say it.”

Say what? Say the thing she had never allowed herself to finish thinking.

“I am...”

The sentence hung. Man. Woman. Broken. Confused.

Sin. Beloved. All the words fought for space. The one that fit and terrified her most

would not leave. Woman. Not in the way people used it as a category. In the way her bones exhaled when she even considered it. She tested it in silence.

Not in language at first. In feelings. In the way her body relaxed when someone mistook her for what she had not yet dared to become. In the way certain clothes,

worn alone, with the blinds closed, made breathing feel easier. In the way the mirror felt less like an enemy for a split second

when she stopped forcing herself to pose like the man everyone thought she was. The first time she whispered her real name to the mirror, she did not say it like a declaration. She said it like a question.

“Noa,” she tried,

voice barely above a whisper. The sound landed in the room and did not explode. No lightning. No earthquake.

No voice from heaven rebuking her. Just her, her reflection, and a name that felt like it had always been there, waiting for her to admit it belonged.

The mirror did not suddenly transform. Her face was still her face. Bone structure the same. Scars the same. But something subtle shifted.

Instead of seeing herself as a man failing to be man enough, she saw, for the first time, a woman doing an excellent job of pretending to be someone else.

It made her angry. At herself. At God. At the world.

“How long,” she asked the reflection,

“have you been here waiting for me to stop lying?”

She did not get an answer. But she knew. Years. Maybe her whole life. The mirror was not kind.

It showed the cost of the good lie. The lines of worry etched into her forehead before their time. The way her eyes dimmed in photos where everyone else saw joy. The way she instinctively pulled back

whenever someone got too close. Who are you if you stop being what they expect? It was a question she had avoided with theology, busyness,

service, romance. The mirror would not let it go. One night, after saying Noa out loud again,

heart pounding, hands shaking, she did something she had never done. She smiled at herself. Not the smile she used on stage.

Not the polite smile for relatives. Not the half-smirk for photos. A small, almost private smile.

“I see you,” she whispered.

It felt like blasphemy and worship in the same breath. For years, she had been taught that to affirm this was to rebel against God. She was only beginning to consider

that maybe God had seen her the whole time. That maybe the mirror was not asking her to replace His voice, but to finally admit she had not heard Him clearly over the roar of everyone else’s certainty. The mirror did not solve anything.

It did not change her name on documents. It did not rewrite her past. It did not tell her what to do next. But it broke one agreement: the agreement that she would keep calling the performance

truth. For the first time, she looked at herself and allowed what she saw to interrupt what she had been told. That interruption would cost her.

It would also save her.

Chapter 5

The First Name She Chose

The first time Noa said her name to someone else, it felt less like an introduction and more like a confession. She had practised it in the mirror. Whispered it in empty rooms.

Written it in notebooks she hid like contraband. Noa. Two syllables. Soft, but not fragile. Short, but not small.

It felt like water in her mouth after years of dust. But a name is only half alive when it exists only inside your own head. At some point, it has to leave the safety of imagination

and risk the air. The opportunity came in a place where she was almost anonymous. A support group. A room with plastic chairs,

bad coffee, and people who had each brought their own versions of almost. Almost left. Almost stayed. Almost died.

Almost believed. She sat near the back, hands clasped, heart pounding. The facilitator smiled with the kind of tired warmth

that said she had heard more stories than most people could handle.

“We’ll go around,” she said.

“Share as much or as little as you like.

Name, pronouns, why you’re here, if you want.” Name. The word landed like a dare. People began.

“Hi, I’m Lina.”

“I’m Marcus.”

“I’m Jo.”

Each name made hers feel heavier. When the circle edged closer, she considered lying. Giving the old name. The safe one.

The one that would not make anyone tilt their head. She had done it before. Every form. Every doctor’s office.

Every bureaucratic counter. The good lie was muscle memory. It showed up now. Just say it, it whispered. It is easier.

You do not owe these strangers your truth. But there was another voice. Quieter. Stubborn. We have already lied to survive.

Let us not lie to heal.

“Your turn,” the facilitator said gently.

All eyes turned. Not hostile. Not prying. Just present. She opened her mouth.

Felt the old name push to the front, familiar and unwanted. She swallowed it. And chose.

“My name is Noa,” she said.

Silence. Not the heavy silence that drips with judgment. Just that small pause where reality rearranges itself around a new piece of information. Then the facilitator nodded.

“Hi, Noa,” she said,

simply. The circle echoed.

“Hi, Noa.”

No one asked,

“So what was it before?”

No one said,

“Your real name, please.”

No one tilted their head and said,

“That’s not what it says on your ID.”

They just received it. As if it were obvious that a person is who she says she is. The miracle was not noisy. No angels.

No visions. Just a room full of tired people using the name she chose like it had always belonged to her. Her body noticed before her mind did.

Shoulders dropping a fraction. Jaw unclenching. Breath deepening. Something in her spine straightened that had nothing to do with posture.

Belonging has a sound. It sounds like your name spoken without hesitation. The facilitator moved on.

“Pronouns?” she asked.

This part felt like walking off a cliff.

“She/her,” Noa said.

Another small pause. Another rearrangement. Then:

“Okay,” the facilitator replied,

as if it were the most natural thing. No one debated. No one quoted. No one cross-examined her history to see if she had earned those syllables.

They moved on. It was almost offensive how simple it was. After years of arguments in her head, years of sermons, family conversations,

medical forms, this room had offered her what felt like the one thing she had almost never been given: unquestioned naming.

Later, during a break, someone from the group came up to her. Short hair. Soft eyes. Hands wrapped around a paper cup.

“It’s good to meet you, Noa,” they said.

They smiled. Did not flinch over the vowels. Did not stumble. She almost cried. Not because no one had ever been kind before.

Because kindness had rarely come without cost or condition.

“What brought you here?” they asked.

Noa took a breath.

“How honest do you want me to be?” she replied.

They chuckled.

“As honest as you can handle.”

It was the first time she told even a sketch of her story to someone who had not already decided what it meant. She did not start with theology. She did not start with politics.

She did not start with debates she had half-memorised to survive conversations. She started with this:

“I’ve spent my whole life

trying to be someone that name needed me to be. I’m just tired.” They nodded.

“Names can do that,” they said.

“Wear you out.”

No lecture. No but what about. No horror story disguised as caution. Just recognition. When she left that night,

walking home under a sky that did not care what anyone was called, she replayed the moment over and over. My name is Noa. Hi, Noa.

It was such a small exchange to anyone else. To her, it was the first time the truth had been spoken out loud and not immediately argued with.

In every other space where she had tried to inch toward herself, someone had rushed in to correct.

“God doesn’t make mistakes.”

“Think about your family.”

“Have you prayed enough?”

“This is just a phase.”

“This is rebellion.”

Every sentence was another way of saying: We refuse to believe you know who you are better than we do. This room had done something radical: believed her at the level of a name.

The miracle was not transition as spectacle. It was being named without argument. She knew this did not solve everything. Tomorrow, legal documents would still disagree. Family members would still slip,

and some would refuse to change. Churches would still pray for her return. But something irreversible had begun. She had heard herself tell the truth in front of witnesses who responded

with acceptance instead of correction. She could not unhear that. Names are more than labels. They are invitations. To show up.

To exist. To be called on. For the first time,

Present

felt like an honest answer.

“My name is Noa,” she whispered again that night

before sleep. Not as a question. Not as a rehearsal. As a fact. And somewhere between the mirror and that small room,

the good lie lost a little more power. Because once you have tasted being seen without having to argue for your own existence, returning to being a good lie feels less like obedience

and more like betrayal. Not of them. Of herself.

Chapter 6

The Body She Couldn't Live In

Before Noa ever moved out of a house, she had already learned what it meant to feel homeless inside her own skin. They had told her the body was a temple. It sounded beautiful in sermons.

Sacred. Elevated. No one explained what to do when the temple felt like it had been built for a different god. Her body was supposed to be

a house she could grow into. Broad shoulders. Strong hands. A voice dropping at the right age. People nodded, satisfied.

“Look at him.”

“He’s becoming a man.”

“He looks just like his father.”

The compliments felt like graffiti on walls that were never hers. Every inch of growth was documented. Height marks on the doorframe. Comments at family gatherings.

Pats on the back that landed like nails.

“Soon you’ll be the man of the house,” they said.

She smiled. Inside, she wondered why every compliment felt like another room being locked from the outside. The body was supposed to be home.

For Noa, it felt like a lease she had never agreed to. If her body was a house, it was one she walked through as if everything inside belonged to someone else.

Hands that did what they were told. Legs that went where they were sent. Chest that carried the weight of expectation. She cleaned it. Fed it.

Disciplined it. Did all the things you are supposed to do to be a good tenant. But she never unpacked. She moved like someone

who knew she might have to leave at any moment. Even in stillness, there was an exit plan built into her bones. There were small ways she tried

to rearrange the house. Clothes chosen not only to hide, but to hint. A softer fabric. A different cut.

An earring. A bracelet. Small changes that felt massive. To others, they might have looked trivial. To her, they were like moving one piece of furniture at a time

in a house where everyone else insisted nothing needed to change. Each adjustment made the mirror a fraction more bearable. Each adjustment also risked being noticed.

“Why are you dressed like that?”

“Trying something new?”

“That’s not very manly.”

Every comment was a hand trying to push her back into a room she had just stepped out of. Outside her skin, paper confirmed what the world believed. Birth certificate.

ID. Medical records. Church membership forms. Each document was another lock. Her name printed in fonts

that had never met her. Gender markers ticked without her consent. Every time she had to hand over a piece of plastic with the old information,

it felt like lending someone keys to a house she was trying to move out of.

“Sign here,” they would say.

“I need to update your file.”

She felt the weight of ink like a chain. It is difficult to claim a new room when every official door still insists you live in the old one.

Some days, she avoided appointments because the thought of hearing that name called out loud, of seeing that box checked again, was more than she could manage. People called it irresponsibility.

She called it self-defence. Clothes became negotiation. Every shirt, every pair of trousers, every pair of shoes

was a compromise between survival and self. She knew what was expected. Certain colours. Certain cuts. Certain silhouettes that signalled

acceptable man. She wore them like uniforms. They made other people comfortable. They made her disappear. On stolen days,

when she was alone enough to risk it, she experimented. A dress. A blouse. Something small but undeniable.

She did not always love the result. This was not about copying other women. It was about finding what felt like it had been hers all along. Sometimes she would stand there,

in front of the mirror, in clothes that finally reflected the inner shape, and feel a grief so deep she could not name it. Not because fabric was magic,

but because it showed her how long she had been living in borrowed furniture. Her voice was another room she had been taught to inhabit in a certain way.

“Speak up.”

“Sound confident.”

“Don’t sound soft.”

“Men don’t whine.”

She lowered it. Flattened it. Cut the edges. She learned how to speak in a register that did not belong to her,

because people around her had decided what the voice of a man should sound like. When she laughed in a way that felt natural, someone always noticed.

“You sound different.”

“Why are you talking like that?”

Every remark was a hand on her throat. So she built a room out of tone. A room that echoed with the version of her they expected.

Polite. Measured. Masculine enough. It did not matter if the words were honest when the room itself was a lie.

The first time someone called her Noa and used she in the same breath, her voice shifted. Not dramatically. Subtly.

She noticed how a certain softness returned without effort. How jokes landed differently when she was not pretending to laugh as the wrong person.

Her voice began to feel less like a room she had rented and more like a space she was finally allowed to decorate. There is a particular kind of exhaustion

that comes from living in a place where you can never fully relax. Noa carried that exhaustion in her muscles. In her back.

In the way she slept like someone ready to move at any moment. The body she couldn’t live in was not empty. It was full of scripts.

Memories. Instructions. Stand like this. Don't gesture like that. Don't cross your legs that way.

Don't sway your hips when you walk. Each rule another nail. If her body was a house, it had been furnished by committee. Family.

Culture. Church. Doctors. Friends. Everyone had an opinion about what belonged where. Almost no one asked what actually felt like home. Leaving did not happen all at once. She did not wake up and simply abandon the old structure.

She began by refusing small things. Refusing certain haircuts. Refusing certain clothes. Refusing certain postures. Refusing to answer to the old name

in spaces where she had a choice. Each refusal was a suitcase packed. Each acceptance of herself was a box carried out. The body she couldn't live in

did not disappear. Leaving it was not as simple as changing outfits. But she had to admit, at last, that staying there only because other people

had invested in its construction was slowly killing her. And survival, as she was starting to understand, sometimes meant being willing

to walk out of a house everyone else called blessing, and trust that the God who supposedly lived there could also meet her

in the hallway between the body she had and the body she was still learning how to inhabit.

Chapter 7

The Church That Prayed for the Wrong Person

Noa did not leave God. God had been the only one she talked to when everyone else was busy deciding who she was allowed to be. What she left, slowly and painfully, was the church that could not imagine God loving her as she was.

From the beginning, church had been home. Songs she knew by heart. Faces she had watched grow older. The smell of coffee, dust,

perfume, Bibles. She had cried at altars. Laughed in foyers. Served in ministries.

Confessed sins that made leaders nod approvingly.

“Honest young man.”

“Sensitive to the Spirit.”

“God’s hand is on his life.”

They meant it as blessing. It landed on her like a prediction she did not know how to live up to. When cracks started showing, she did what she had been taught.

She asked for prayer. Not for a new name. Not for a new body. At first, just for peace.

“I feel... off,” she told a leader once.

“Like I’m not fully myself.”

He put a hand on her shoulder.

“Everyone feels odd sometimes,” he said.

“Especially at your age.

The enemy loves confusion.” He prayed.

“Lord, we come against confusion.

We thank You for the man of God You are forming here. Give him strength to walk in the identity You have given him.” She said amen. Because that is what you do. You say amen even when the prayer is for someone

you no longer recognise. As Noa inched closer to the truth, word spread. Not all at once. Not formally.

Churches leak too. Someone saw a social media post. Someone heard she had been at those meetings. Someone noticed changes they did not like. Clothes.

Hair. A name that sounded too soft in someone else’s mouth. Concerns grew. They did what they always did with concerns.

They turned them into prayer requests. Not with her in the room. In circles. In small groups. In leadership meetings.

“Let’s pray for him,” they would say,

using the old name.

“He’s going through something.”

“He’s confused.”

“He’s under attack.”

“We don’t want to lose him.”

They meant well, most of them. They were not trying to destroy her. Most of them were simply afraid. Afraid of losing the story they had built around her.

The good son. The faithful young man. The future leader. Afraid that if her story changed, maybe theirs could too.

Afraid that if God could be with her on the path she was taking, then maybe He was bigger than the box they had carefully inherited. So they prayed for the version of her

they could handle.

“Bring him back, Lord.”

“Restore his true identity.”

“Remind him who he really is in You.”

“Take away this deception.”

Every sentence was a rope thrown toward a person she no longer was. They did not realise they were asking God to resurrect the very lie that had been suffocating her.

She heard about these prayers in fragments. Someone told her,

“We’re praying for you.

We know this isn’t really you.” Another said,

“I remember the real you.

He’s still in there. We’re asking God to bring him out.” Real. He. She wanted to answer,

Maybe the person you called real was the most edited version I could manage. She wanted to ask, Do you understand what you are asking God to do

when you beg Him to bring back a self that nearly killed me? She did not. Not always. Sometimes, she was too tired.

Sometimes, she did not want to fight over language with people who believed they were saving her. There was a day she went back. Not to be dramatic.

Just to see. She sat near the back, cap pulled low, body pulled in. The sermon that morning was about identity.

Of course it was. Verses she knew by heart. Male and female. Fearfully and wonderfully made. New creation.

Old has gone, new has come. She could have preached it herself. The pastor's eyes moved across the room. They landed on her for a second. He smiled with pastoral concern.

"Some of you," he said,

"are being lied to about who you are.

The world is trying to tell you that you can choose your identity. But God already chose it for you." Amens scattered across the room. She swallowed. Was he talking about her?

Maybe. Maybe not. She had reached a point where it did not matter. The words still cut.

Not because she did not believe God had a say in who she was. Because she had begun to suspect that what God said and what they repeated in His name

were not always the same. After the service, someone caught her. An older woman. One who had known her since Sunday school. She took Noa's hands in hers.

"I'm so glad you came, dear," she said.

"We've been praying for you."

Noa's throat tightened.

"For what, exactly?" she asked.

The woman smiled sadly.

"For you to come back."

"To what?" Noa asked,

soft but firm.

“To the person you were,” the woman replied.

“The man God made you.”

There it was. A prayer request turned into a script. Noa pulled her hands back gently.

“Maybe,” she said quietly,

“you’ve been praying for the wrong person.”

The woman frowned.

“What do you mean?”

“I mean,” Noa answered,

“the person you are asking God to bring back

is the one who lied for you and called it obedience.” Silence stretched.

“That version nearly died

trying to make you proud,” Noa continued.

“I won’t ask God to resurrect a lie.”

At night, alone, Noa still prayed. Not always with words. Sometimes just by breathing through the panic and asking,

“Are You here?”

She needed to separate God from the voices that had used His name to keep her small.

“Are You angry?”

“Are You disappointed?”

“Did I step outside Your will

by stepping inside my own truth?” Silence. Then, over time, not answers,

but Presence. In moments no one else saw. A bus ride where a stranger's kindness made her cry. A sunset that felt like a wink. A passage

of Scripture

that refused to behave the way it had always been preached. Before I formed you in the womb, I knew you. She had heard it her whole life.

This time, the emphasis shifted. Not: Before I formed your body, I locked you into a role. But:

Before I formed you, I knew you. Knew. Not mislabelled. Not misgendered.

Not misread. Knew. What if, she dared to imagine, God had known her as Noa

long before anybody else could handle it? What if the One they claimed she was rebelling against had always seen her as the woman she was finally allowing herself to be? It did not solve the tension overnight.

She still flinched at certain songs. Certain phrases. Certain prayers. She still felt anger at the church that had prayed with such sincerity

for the death of the version of her that was finally honest. But little by little, she began to distinguish between the God she met in quiet places and the god they invoked

to keep her compliant. One asked her to lie less. The other asked her to disappear. She chose. Not easily.

Not cleanly. But she chose.

"If the choice," she whispered once,

“is between the God who supposedly only loves me as a lie,
and the God who might love me in truth, I will risk the latter.”
Eventually, she stopped letting that church pray for her. Not because
she believed prayer was useless.

Because she knew they were not praying for the person she was.
They were praying for a hypothetical former version who fit better
inside their theology. She stepped down from ministries. Stopped
attending meetings that existed to fix her.

When people messaged,
“We’re interceding,”
she replied,
“Thank you,”
when she could, and sometimes,
“Please don’t.”
It shocked them.
“Why wouldn’t you want prayer?”

Because, she could not always explain, prayer aimed at my erasure
is not love. One day, she imagined a different circle.

People around her, not praying for the boy they believed she had
lost, but for the woman she had finally stopped running from.

“God,
help Noa stay. Help her be honest. Help her heal the parts we
broke with our certainty. Help us repent where we called harm
holiness.”

She did not know if she would ever hear those words from the
mouths that once blessed her for being a solid man. But she knew this
much: She would rather stand alone

before a God who saw her than live surrounded by people who loved only the version of her that was slowly dying so they could keep their theology tidy.

Chapter 8

Men Who Wanted Her in the Dark

When Noa began to live more openly as herself, men did not all react the same way. Some stepped away immediately, with the quick horror of people afraid to be seen even in the same photograph.

Others remained polite. Civil. Distant. And then there was the third kind. The ones who only found courage when the lights were off.

Men who never greeted her in public, but somehow knew what time she left work. Men who followed her online, watched the changes, noticed the softness arriving,

and said nothing where anyone else could hear. They did not want her in daylight. They wanted her in the dark. Where no one had to call desire by its name.

At first, the messages rarely looked dangerous. A late-night text. Hey, are you awake? An ambiguous invitation. Can we talk? I just want to understand.

A long conversation dressed as innocence. I want to hear your story. Noa knew not every man who asked questions meant harm. But she learned quickly the difference between a man who wanted to listen and a man who needed an excuse to come closer.

The ones who wanted to listen asked questions that recognised her. How was it for you? What hurt the most? What are you building now?

The others moved quickly toward the edges of her body.

So...

how does it work? Have you already...? Can I be honest? I've always been curious. Curiosity. A neutral word that, in certain mouths,

smelled like consumption. The pattern repeated. By day, men who barely greeted Noa at church, at work,

in the street. By night, those same men appeared on her screen with sentences they would never dare to say out loud. Some did not hide behind theology

or careful language. They called her a fantasy. An experience. Something I always wanted to try. Someone like you.

They said like you as if it were a compliment. But the phrase arrived carrying its own cage. They did not see her as someone with limits, fears,

history, faith, memory. They saw her as a category. I've heard about people like you,

but I've never met one. People like you. They forgot that the thing feeding their curiosity was the daily reality she had paid for with family,

with church, with blood, with years of disappearing. When a man wanted her only as a secret chapter in his private book of experiences,

there was no room for Noa to be more than an object. If she spoke about pain, they changed the subject. If she mentioned faith, they smiled like it did not belong in the same room as desire.

If she set limits, they called her cold. I just want to be close to you, they said. But close meant a dark room,

an anonymous bed, a deleted conversation afterwards. Never a table. Never daylight. Never friends.

Never, This is Noa. There was a pattern that began to wound more than it fascinated. They came to her carrying desire and shame. Desire,

because something about her truly drew them in. Shame, because they had been taught that wanting her said something terrible about them. Instead of facing their own conflict,

they handed it to her. You make me feel things I shouldn't feel. I don't know what this says about me. If anyone knew I was talking to you... Underneath it all:

You are the problem, not the way I was taught to fear my own body, my own curiosity, my own desire.

The pattern was cruel. In the dark, they called her beautiful, irresistible, different.

By morning, they called themselves sick, sinful, confused. And to survive their own shame,

they needed to turn her into temptation. You led me into this. You know the effect you have. You like this power. They did not see that the real power

still lived in their hands. The power to decide when she was a person and when she was only a hidden adventure.

Some men, braver in the dark than in the sun, tried to move one step closer. I want to see you, they said.

But let's meet somewhere no one knows us. When they crossed paths by accident in public, their bodies betrayed what their mouths denied. A quick look. A faster turn.

A small nod, if that. Later, that same night: Sorry I didn't speak. You know how it is.

People from church were around. Or: People at work talk. You know how they are. Noa began to realise that some men had two maps of their lives.

One official map, clean, wide, well lit, where they walked hand in hand

with girlfriends, fiancées, wives the world recognised as normal. And another map,

hidden, made of alleys, tunnels, rented rooms, anonymous calls,

deleted messages, where they stored everything they did not know how to include in the public version of themselves. Noa lived on the second map. In the alleys.

In the meetings arranged far from familiar streets. In the grey space between desire and denial. When they wanted to look holy, they erased her from the map. When they wanted to feel alive,

they found her again. Being visible as Noa came with a double cost. On one side, it allowed her to finally breathe

as the person she was. On the other, it made her a target for men who saw in her two things at once: enough risk to excite them,

enough vulnerability to believe they would never be exposed. You understand, they said. You know what it's like to be rejected. As if rejection gave them permission to use her.

They came with stories of their own. Empty marriages. Delayed engagements. Hidden relationships. Ruined faith.

But in the end, they always returned to the same centre: her body, her mystery, the possibility of being close to something

their world had turned into both fascination and horror. Noa understood that part of the attraction came from the feeling that with her there was no script they had to follow.

They felt free to experiment with what they would never admit they wanted. But that freedom was brutally uneven. They could return to normal whenever they wanted. She could not.

It took time for Noa to name the pattern as violence. For a while, she called it the price of being who she was. This is how it is, she told herself.

People still do not know how to handle me. But eventually, the nights began to hurt more than they were worth. It was not desire itself. It was what came after.

The silence. The guilt they projected. The retreat. She began to ask questions she used to avoid. Will you speak to me in daylight?

If someone asks who I am, what will you say? Do you see me as a person or as an episode? Some disappeared immediately.

Others tried to negotiate. Do not complicate this. You do not need to make it a big thing. Let it be just ours. Just ours.

Words that sounded like intimacy, but were really another name for hiding. One night, in the middle of another late conversation

with another man who wanted her only in the dark, Noa wrote: If you cannot want me with the lights on, you do not deserve me in the dark. She did not send it that night.

But she kept it. And with time, she learned to live it. She became careful about who she allowed into the most intimate rooms of her new house.

Not because she had stopped longing for connection. But because she finally understood that being desired in secret was not enough to pay the cost of being dehumanised.

The men who wanted her in the dark were not the whole story. But they were an important part of it. They taught her, without meaning to,

that some attractions, some curiosities, some almost-loves, prefer secrecy because they are not willing to pay the price

of seeing clearly. Noa, who had spent too much of her life paying prices for other people, decided,

little by little, that she would no longer offer her visibility to anyone who was not willing to offer, in return, the courage to be seen beside her.

Chapter 9

The Name on the Papers

There are people who only know you on paper. To them, you are a file. A number. A line in a system that mistakes permanence for truth.

By the time Noa had learned how to say her own name aloud, how to hear it in kind rooms, how to wear it without apologising, the world of paper still disagreed. Not loudly.

Not emotionally. That was almost worse. People can scream your old name and at least reveal their cruelty. Paper does not scream.

Paper just sits there, calm and official, insisting on a version of you that your soul left years ago. At work, the first problem was not philosophy.

It was payroll.

“Your records don’t match.”

“HR needs clarification.”

“We have to use your legal name for now.”

For now. A phrase that sounds temporary until you realise systems are built to stretch for now into years. Emails arrived with the wrong name in bold.

Staff rosters printed the old one. Access cards. Internal databases. Insurance forms. Each document was a tiny resurrection.

Not of a person. Of an assignment. Someone she had inhabited for survival was being kept alive by admin. Noa learned that bureaucracy does not care about revelation.

It cares about consistency. If the file said one thing and her mouth said another, the file won. And people,

polite, busy, ordinary people, would hide behind it.

“I’m sorry, it’s just the system.”

“I totally respect you, but legally...”

“My hands are tied.”

Hands are often tied most tightly when no one wants to take responsibility for untying them. There are few humiliations as specific as handing someone an identification card that names a ghost.

At airports. At pharmacies. At reception desks. At banks. Her face in front of them.

Her voice in the room. Her name on her lips. And then, the old card. A pause.

A look. Eyes flicking from photo to person, from print to presence. Sometimes the pause lasted only a second. Sometimes it became an interrogation.

“Is this yours?”

“Has this been altered?”

“What is your actual name?”

“So... what should I call you?”

What should I call you. As if the answer had not already been standing there the whole time. Noa would say it calmly.

“Noa.”

Some accepted it. Some stumbled. Some smirked. Some used the old name again with the satisfaction of people who think official ink

gives them moral authority. The card did not just identify. It betrayed. It opened a second file inside the room, one where strangers suddenly believed

they were entitled to the archaeology of her life. Work became its own theatre of polite violence. Not the obvious kind. No one stood up in meetings to denounce her.

It was subtler. A manager who said,

“We support everyone here,”

and then introduced her with the old name because that is what payroll uses. A colleague who got it right in person and wrong in emails because,

“I don’t want to create confusion.”

A system update that changed her preferred name on one platform but not on the others, so she lived split-screen: Noa in the kitchen, the old name in the database,

both supposedly the same employee. It is hard to do ordinary work when every login feels like a miniature denial. Hard to answer calls, join meetings,

sign forms, when the infrastructure beneath your day keeps insisting you are someone you had to survive. People talk often about discrimination

as if it always arrives dramatically. Sometimes it arrives as repetition. The wrong name in ten small places before lunch. By the end of the day, it was not one insult.

It was erosion. If work was tiring, medical spaces were worse. Because medicine deals in bodies, and bodies had always been the place

where Noa was most contested. Waiting rooms were their own kind of public trial. A nurse at the door calling the old name into a room full of strangers. Heads turning.

Her body tightening before her mind could catch up. She would stand anyway. Walk forward anyway. Carry dignity like a glass of water she refused to spill.

“Preferred name?” they would ask at the desk,

after already using the wrong one out loud. Preferred. As if truth were a flavour. As if Noa were a customisation setting. Then the forms.

Sex: Male. Female. Other. Tick one.

Medical history fields that did not have room for a life like hers. Questions delivered with sterile smiles and unsterile curiosity.

“So what exactly are you?”

“Have you had the surgery?”

“When did this start?”

“What was your name before?”

Before. Medical systems loved before. Loved origin stories. Loved baseline categories. They did not always know how to care

for the person in front of them without first reducing her to a case study. She understood that some questions mattered. Bodies need competent care.

But there is a difference between being treated and being examined for the comfort of someone else’s certainty. Too often,

official spaces confused the two. Changing a name sounds simple to people who have never needed a new one to stay alive.

“Just file the paperwork.”

“Just update your documents.”

“Just follow the process.”

Just. As if the process were not built like a maze. Forms requiring proof of who she was from institutions that still insisted on who she had been.

Fees. Affidavits. Appointments. Waiting periods. Clerks behind glass looking at her

with the blank power of people who can delay a life without ever raising their voice. Each office had its own ritual. Take a number. Sit down.

Approach when called. State your reason. State your reason. She wanted to say: Because the name you have on file

is a coffin I keep getting asked to climb back into. Instead, she learned the language of bureaucracy.

“I’m requesting a legal name change.”

“I need to amend my records.”

“I’m bringing the required documents.”

The state prefers your pain formatted neatly. So she formatted it. Bound her life in envelopes. Signed where told.

Smiled when necessary. Waited. And waited. There is a cruelty in how slowly systems move when the person waiting

is trying to become legible to her own life. Private cruelty can be denied. Official cruelty comes with stamps. Deadnaming in personal life

hurts because it is intimate. Deadnaming in official life hurts because it pretends to be neutral.

“It’s not personal.”

“It’s policy.”

“It’s just what’s on the form.”

But impersonality does not reduce harm. It industrialises it. A receptionist reads the wrong name because the screen tells her to. A pharmacist repeats it twice

because she did not hear Noa correct her the first time. A bank employee lowers his voice and says,

“So which one are you really?”

Really. The old word. The old trap. Noa learned that institutions rarely think of themselves as violent.

Violence, in their minds, belongs to fists, threats, slurs. Not forms.

Not databases. Not legal lag. And yet an old version of a person can be kept breathing for years by records alone.

A bureaucratic ghost. A state-sponsored haunting. This was the strangest part: she had already left that old self behind in the places that mattered most.

In the mirror. In prayer. In rooms where people called her Noa without flinching. But official space kept reviving her.

Not fully. Just enough to exhaust her. Just enough to remind her that recognition is not evenly distributed. A person can be loved by friends,

known by herself, named rightly by God, and still be misfiled by a clerk with a slow keyboard. The old version of her

survived longest where no one needed to believe in souls. Only documentation. Maybe that was the deepest insult. That systems built to organise human life could so easily become machines for preserving

an abandoned script. Noa had not chosen to be haunted. But the papers did not care what she had chosen. They cared what had been entered first.

As if first meant truest. As if origin outranked revelation. One day, after months of forms and corrections, she stood at a counter

waiting for a new document. The woman behind the glass looked bored. Efficient. Neither kind nor cruel.

Just employed. She typed. Printed. Stamped. Slid the paper forward.

Noa looked down. There it was. Her name. Noa. No debate.

No parentheses. No former identity trailing after it like a legal footnote. Just the name. For a second, the room blurred.

Not because the piece of paper was holy. Because after so long being contradicted by institutions, there is a particular relief in seeing the state

finally stop arguing with your existence. The clerk did not notice the significance.

“Next,” she called.

Of course. Miracles in bureaucracies rarely get music. Noa stepped aside, paper in hand,

and stared. It was not salvation. But it was evidence. That a system which had once kept the ghost alive

could, reluctantly, slowly, be made to release it. Even then, not everything changed.

Old records lingered. Archived files. Legacy systems. People who had memorised the old version and preferred it.

Bureaucratic hauntings do not end all at once. But something fundamental had shifted. For the first time, the public record had begun to catch up with the private truth.

The name on the papers did not make her real. It acknowledged what had already been real for much longer than the file knew. The state can keep

an old version of a person alive long after the soul has left it. But not forever. Not if the person whose life is being misfiled keeps showing up

to counters, to offices, to windows behind glass, and saying, calmly, again and again:

That is not my name. This is.

Chapter 10

The People Who Left

Some people left with noise. Doors slammed. Messages arrived in paragraphs full of scripture, fear, anger,

disappointment. Some called it love. Some called it truth. Some called it correction. Noa learned that people often give holy names

to the things they cannot bear to feel honestly. But not everyone left loudly. Some people left like lights turning off in rooms she used to enter without thinking. A slower kind of absence. A reply that never came.

An invitation that stopped appearing. A birthday message that became shorter every year until it disappeared completely. People imagine loss as a dramatic scene. A final argument.

A cruel sentence. A clean ending. But some losses do not announce themselves. They simply reduce the space you are allowed to occupy in someone else's life.

At first, Noa tried to explain. To family. To friends. To church people. To people who said they loved her,

but always seemed to love her more when she was easier to misunderstand. She sent careful messages. Not angry. Not theatrical.

Careful.

"I know this is difficult."

"I am still me."

"I am not trying to hurt you."

“I just cannot keep living as someone I never truly was.”

Some replied with silence. Some replied with grief so heavy it became accusation.

“It feels like we lost you.”

“We don’t know who you are anymore.”

“You changed.”

Noa would read those sentences and feel something inside her twist. Because part of her understood. They had known a version of her for years. A version who carried chairs, answered to the old name,

wore the right clothes, served the right ministries, smiled when praised for disappearing. To them, that version had been real. To Noa, that version had been survival.

Both things could be true. That was what made it harder. Cruel people were easier to grieve. You could point to the wound and name it. But the people who left sadly,

softly, with trembling voices and wet eyes, were harder. They did not always hate her. Some simply could not follow her

without losing the shape of their own certainty. Her mother did not scream the first time Noa asked her to use her name. That might have been simpler. Instead, she sat very still, hands folded in her lap,

eyes fixed on a corner of the room.

“Noa,” she repeated,

as if the sound had sharp edges. Then she cried. Not loudly. Not dramatically. Just quietly,

like someone watching a house burn from far away. Noa wanted to comfort her. That was the old reflex. Make other people comfortable even when their discomfort was built on her erasure.

She almost said,

“It’s okay.”

But it was not. So she said nothing. Her mother whispered,

“I gave you a good name.”

Noa nodded.

“I know.”

“I prayed over it.”

“I know.”

“I loved you with that name.”

Noa closed her eyes.

“I know.”

And that was the terrible part. The name had not been given with hatred. It had been given with hope. Wrapped in love. Held up to God.

Celebrated. That did not make it less wrong for the woman who had to live inside it. A cage can be built by loving hands. It is still a cage. Her father handled it differently.

He became practical. Distant. Polite in the way men become polite when tenderness feels like humiliation. He did not ask many questions. He did not say much about God.

He simply began speaking around her. At family gatherings, he would talk to everyone else more easily than he talked to Noa. If he needed to refer to her, he paused. As if every sentence required negotiation.

Noa could see the effort. That almost made it worse. Because effort without acceptance can still feel like rejection wearing good manners.

Siblings were different. Some were curious. Some protective. Some embarrassed. One cousin unfollowed her without a word.

Another sent a long message about family shame and how people were talking. People were always talking. That was the family gospel before it was ever Noa's problem.

"What are we supposed to tell people?" someone asked.

Noa stared at the message for a long time. Then typed:

"The truth would be a start."

She did not send it. Not that day. Instead, she put the phone down and let herself feel the particular loneliness of being treated like a public relations crisis

by people who once called you blessing. Friends left too. Not all. But enough. Some left because they did not agree.

Some left because they were afraid of what agreeing would cost them. Some stayed in theory but disappeared in practice. They liked posts about kindness. Shared quotes about loving everyone.

Sent hearts on difficult days. But when Noa needed someone to sit beside her in a waiting room, or walk with her into a family event, or correct the old name when she was too tired to do it again,

they were busy. Kindness from distance is easy. Presence is where love becomes expensive. Church people left with the most language. They knew how to make abandonment sound spiritual.

"We love you, but we cannot affirm this."

"We are praying for restoration."

"We believe God has a better plan."

"We cannot walk with you down this path."

This path. As if Noa had chosen a road lined with neon rebellion instead of crawling toward honesty with bleeding knees. They called it separation. Boundaries.

Conviction. Noa called it what it felt like: being buried by people who insisted they were only protecting the grave. There were lovers who left too. Some before they could be called lovers.

Men who desired her until desire required courage. Men who loved the mystery but not the daylight. Men who said,

“You know I care about you,”

while backing away from anything that would make caring visible. One man told her,

“I just don’t know how to explain this to people.”

Noa looked at him and almost laughed. Not because it was funny. Because it was so familiar. People were always asking how to explain her. As if love were a presentation.

As if dignity needed a speech before it could be offered.

“You don’t have to explain me,” she said.

“You have to decide whether you are ashamed of standing next to me.”

He did not answer. That was the answer. There were days when the leaving made her hard. She told herself she did not care. That she was better off.

That anyone who could not love her as Noa had never truly loved her at all. Sometimes that was true. Sometimes it was only armour. Because grief is complicated when the people who hurt you

also made you soup when you were sick, picked you up from school, prayed over exams, danced with you at weddings, sent money when you were broke,

remembered details about your childhood no one else knew. Noa had to learn that losing people does not always mean they were never good. Sometimes it means their goodness had borders and you finally reached them.

That realization hurt more than hatred. Hatred could be rejected. Borders had to be mourned. One night, after another person she loved sent another message beginning with

“I hope you understand,”

Noa sat on the floor beside her bed and cried without elegance. Not cinematic tears. Not soft literary sadness. The ugly kind.

The kind that makes the body fold. The kind that asks God questions with no grammar.

“Why does becoming myself cost so many people?”

No answer came. Only the room. Only breath. Only the awful truth that freedom does not always arrive with applause. Sometimes freedom arrives holding a list of names

you are going to miss. After that night, Noa stopped pretending that everyone who left was simply evil. Some were cruel. Some were cowardly. Some were grieving a person who had never really been allowed to live.

Some loved her as far as their fear would let them. And some loved the old name more than they loved the woman who survived it. That was the part she had to stop arguing with. Love that requires your disappearance

is not love you can safely live inside. So she let some people leave. Not because it did not hurt. Because begging them to stay often meant shrinking herself back into the shape

they were willing to hold. And she had already spent too much of her life being held as someone else. The people who left took things

with them. Shared memories.

Family jokes. Old photographs. Familiar prayers. Versions of home. But they did not take Noa.

They did not take the name. They did not take the woman who had finally begun to understand that being abandoned for telling the truth was painful,

but still less deadly than being loved for a lie.

Chapter 11

The Ones Who Stayed

Not everyone left. That was the mercy Noa almost missed because grief has a way of counting exits more carefully than doors that remain open. Some people stayed. Not loudly.

Not with speeches. Not with dramatic declarations about being brave enough to love her. They stayed in ordinary ways. A message that still came. A seat saved beside them.

A name used correctly when Noa was not in the room to hear it. The first ones who stayed did not always understand everything. Noa had to learn that understanding and love do not always arrive on the same day.

Some people loved first and learned slowly. Others asked questions with care, not curiosity dressed as hunger.

"What do you need me to know?"

"How do I support you without making you teach me everything?"

"Do you want me to correct people when they use the old name?"

Noa did not know how to answer at first. She was used to defending herself. She was used to preparing evidence. She was used to entering conversations as if she were already on trial. Kindness without a trap felt suspicious.

A friend named Lina was one of the first. Lina did not make Noa's life into a project. She did not post about allyship. She did not turn Noa into proof of her own goodness. She simply stayed.

When Noa had appointments, Lina asked,

"Do you want company?"

Not,

"Are you sure you can handle this?"

Not,

"I can't imagine how hard this is."

Just:

"Do you want company?"

Sometimes Noa said yes. Sometimes no. Lina respected both. That alone felt like a kind of shelter. Once, in a waiting room,

a nurse called the old name. Noa froze. Her body knew how to obey before her spirit could resist. Lina stood first.

"She goes by Noa," she said.

Calm. Clear. No performance. The nurse blinked, looked down at the file, then back up.

"Noa?"

Noa breathed.

"Yes."

It was such a small thing. A correction in a room full of plastic chairs. But small things can become altars when they happen in places where you expected to be alone. There was also her younger sister.

Not perfect. Not immediate. At first, she stumbled. Used the old name by habit. Apologised too much.

Corrected herself with panic in her eyes, as if every mistake might make Noa leave forever. Noa had to tell her,

"I need you to try.

I don't need you to perform guilt every time you fail." Her sister cried. Then listened. Then tried again. That was staying too.

Not flawless acceptance. Not instant maturity. The willingness to be corrected without making the wound about yourself. Months later, at a family dinner, an uncle used the old name.

The table tightened. Noa felt the familiar decision rise inside her: Correct him and become the problem, or stay quiet and betray herself. Before she could speak, her sister did.

"She said her name is Noa."

No speech. No shaking voice. Just truth placed on the table beside the plates. The uncle muttered something about confusion.

Her sister did not argue. She only repeated,

"Her name is Noa."

Noa looked down at her hands so no one would see how close she was to tears. Being defended without being displayed was a love she was still learning how to receive. And then there was Mara.

Mara had known Noa from church. Older. Quiet. The kind of woman who always carried tissues and never told anyone how many people had cried into them. Mara did not understand everything.

She admitted that.

"I am still learning," she said once,

and for once, the sentence did not sound like a warning. It sounded like humility. When others asked if Mara was still praying for "him," Mara answered,

"I am praying for Noa."

The room shifted. People did not like the sound of that. It made the truth too present. Someone said,

"But you know what we mean."

Mara folded her hands in her lap.

"I do," she said.

"That is why I said Noa."

She did not preach. She did not argue theology in the foyer. She did not need to win the room. She only refused to make prayer another place where Noa disappeared.

Later that week, Noa received a message from her. I prayed for you today. Noa stared at it, bracing herself. Then the next line came. Not for you to go back.

For you to have peace where you are. Noa read it three times. For once, prayer did not feel like a rope dragging her toward an old grave. It felt like a hand left open beside her.

Mara never tried to become the hero of Noa's story. That mattered. She did not say,

"I accept you,"

with the grandeur of someone handing down permission. She said,

"I made soup. Do you want some?"

She said,

"I saved you a seat."

She said,

"I corrected them. You should not have to do it every time."

She said,

"I do not understand everything."

But I know enough not to pray for someone's disappearance and call it love." Noa carried that sentence for a long time. It did not erase the church that hurt her. It did not undo the sermons,

the prayers aimed at her erasure, the meetings where people discussed her like a theological problem. But it made room for a more complicated truth: faith itself was not the enemy. Erasure was.

Some people used God to push her back into a name that nearly killed her. Others, quietly, made space for the possibility that God had been with Noa all along. The ones who stayed did not always know the perfect words.

Sometimes they said things clumsily. Sometimes they asked questions that made her tired. Sometimes they needed correction more than once. But they stayed long enough to learn. They stayed without making her earn their presence by becoming smaller.

They stayed when being seen beside her cost them convenience. That was the difference. Many people had loved Noa when loving her required nothing from them. The ones who stayed loved her when love became visible. When it meant correcting a name at dinner.

Walking into an office. Sitting beside her in church while others stared. Putting Noa in their phone as Noa. Saying "she" without lowering their voice.

Not because they were performing courage, but because love that hides forever starts to look too much like shame. Noa did not trust staying easily. She had watched too many people promise presence

and then disappear when presence became expensive. So when someone stayed, she tested it without meaning to. Pulled back. Went quiet. Expected the message to stop coming.

Expected the chair to disappear. Expected the love to become conditional. Some people failed that test. Others stayed through it. Not because Noa was easy.

She was not always easy. Pain had made her sharp in places. Suspicion had become a reflex. Sometimes she heard rejection in sentences that held none. Sometimes she left rooms emotionally before anyone else had moved.

The ones who stayed did not pretend that her wounds made every reaction holy. They loved her enough to be honest.

"You are safe with me," Lina said once,

"but you still have to tell me when you are scared instead of punishing me for what other people did."

Noa hated hearing it. Then she thanked her three days later. Staying was not worship. It was not allowing Noa to hurt people and call every consequence transphobia, or trauma,

or misunderstanding. It was love with enough dignity to tell the truth in both directions. You are real. You are responsible. You are loved.

You are not alone. Slowly, Noa began to understand that being chosen by the right people did not feel like being put on a pedestal. It felt like being given room.

Room to arrive late to herself. Room to grieve. Room to laugh without explaining why joy still surprised her. Room to be wrong. Room to be ordinary.

That was the gift she had not known she needed: not people who made her identity the centre of every room, but people who made enough space for her to exist without apology. One evening, after dinner with Lina, her sister, and Mara,

Noa walked home with leftovers in a paper bag and a strange ache in her chest. Not grief. Not exactly. Something softer.

The ache of having been loved without being managed. No one had asked for a debate. No one had asked for the old name. No one

had turned her survival into a lesson. They had eaten.

Argued about music. Burned the rice a little. Laughed too loudly. Mara had prayed before the meal, simple and brief.

"God, thank You for everyone at this table.

Help us love without fear. Help us tell the truth without cruelty. Help us stay where love asks us to stay." Noa had kept her eyes open during the prayer. Not out of disrespect.

Because she wanted to see it. A room where her name was not a controversy. A table where faith did not require her disappearance. A life where staying was not another word for being trapped. The ones who stayed did not fix what the others broke.

They could not. But they proved that loss was not the whole story. They proved that love could remain without asking her to return to the version of herself that everyone else found easier.

They proved that some people, when handed the truth, do not use it as a weapon, a sermon, or a test.

Some people hold it carefully. Some people say your name. Some people stay.

Chapter 12

When the Old Name Returned

The old name returned the way old ghosts often do: not with permission, but with timing. Noa had begun to believe not that she was free from it completely,

but that she had learned how to live without flinching every time its shadow crossed a room. Then one afternoon, at a family gathering she had almost talked herself out of, someone said it.

Loudly. Not in a whisper. Not in private. Across a table crowded with plates, voices,

children, and people pretending not to watch her too closely. The old name cut through the room with the confidence of something that had once owned every door inside her.

For a second, everything in Noa went still. Not peaceful still. Animal still. The kind of stillness that happens when the body hears danger

before the mind finds language. Her hand tightened around her glass. A fork stopped halfway to someone's mouth. Conversation bent around the sound and did not know where to land.

The person who said it was an uncle. Of course. Not the cruelest one. Not the loudest.

One of the ones who believed that joking was a softer form of truth. He laughed after saying it, as if laughter could make violence socially acceptable.

"Relax," he said,

before anyone had spoken.

"I'm just used to the old days."

The old days. People loved that phrase. It made harm sound nostalgic. Noa heard her mother inhale. Her sister shifted beside her.

Somebody looked down at their plate. Somebody else looked at Noa, waiting. That was the worst part. The waiting.

Rooms like that always demanded a performance. Would she laugh to keep the peace? Would she correct him and become the difficult one? Would she cry? Would she leave?

Would she prove that everyone's discomfort was justified? The old name hung in the air like a command. For years, that name had been a leash. Someone said it,

and her body came running before her soul could object. Present. Yes. Here.

What do you need? Who do you need me to be? That reflex rose in her now, old and obedient. Her throat almost opened.

Almost answered. Almost returned. But then, something else rose too. Lina's voice in a waiting room: She goes by Noa.

Mara's message: Not for you to go back. For you to have peace where you are. Her sister at the dinner table: Her name is Noa.

The first support group: Hi, Noa. Her own voice in the mirror: I see you. The old name called.

But it was no longer the only sound inside her. Noa placed the glass down. Carefully. Not because she was calm, but because she wanted her hands

to learn a new way of surviving. She looked at her uncle.

"My name is Noa," she said.

No speech. No sermon. No tremor she was willing to give the room. Just the fact. Her uncle rolled his eyes.

"You know what I meant."

"Yes," Noa said.

"I do."

That was all. The room did not know what to do with that. People are prepared for outrage. They are prepared for tears. They are prepared for a debate

they can later describe as proof that you are unstable. They are less prepared for a woman who refuses to make her dignity negotiable. Her uncle muttered,

"Everyone is so sensitive these days."

Noa did not answer. She had learned that not every sentence deserves a doorway. Some sentences are traps built to make you crawl back inside and decorate them with explanation.

She picked up her fork. Took a bite of food she could barely taste. Her body was still shaking under the table. But she stayed.

Not the old stay. Not the stay that meant disappear so everyone else can remain comfortable. This was different. She stayed as herself.

Her sister reached under the table and touched Noa's knee. A small pressure. I am here. Mara was not at that table,

but Noa imagined what she would have said. Breathe. Do not let them make a grave out of a sound. Across from her, her mother was crying quietly.

Noa saw it. The familiar grief. The grief of a woman still learning that accepting Noa did not mean she had failed the child she thought she was raising.

Noa did not rush to rescue her. That too was new. For years, she had managed other people's emotions like an unpaid ministry. If they were confused,

she softened. If they were embarrassed, she disappeared. If they were grieving, she betrayed herself to make their grief less sharp.

Not this time. She let her mother feel what she felt. She let her uncle sit with the correction. She let the table be uncomfortable. Truth often enters a room

before anyone has learned how to host it. After a while, conversation returned. Awkwardly. Too brightly.

Someone asked about work. Someone passed the salad. Children laughed in another room, unaware that a funeral had just happened without music.

Noa felt it. A burial. Not of the old name itself. People might keep using it. Documents might still remember it.

Family memories might still wrap themselves around it. The burial was something else: the belief that she had to answer. That died at the table. Quietly.

Without applause. Later, in the bathroom, Noa locked the door and leaned against the sink. The mirror looked back.

Different room. Same woman. Her hands shook then. Freely. She let them.

Courage does not always mean the body stays calm. Sometimes courage means the body trembles and the soul does not hand over the keys. She looked at herself. Not checking if she looked strong.

Not checking if she looked feminine enough, convincing enough, unbothered enough. Just looking.

"You did not answer," she whispered.

The sentence opened something inside her. A grief. A relief. A strange laugh that almost became a sob.

"You did not answer."

For years, the old name had entered rooms and found her waiting there, trained, available, ready to become whatever kept the peace.

This time, the name entered the room and found no one left inside her willing to answer. That did not mean it had no power. It still had history.

It still had teeth in certain mouths. It still knew where some wounds were buried. But power is not the same as ownership. Pain is not the same as truth.

A name can still hurt you and no longer belong to you. Noa washed her hands. Dried them. Opened the door.

When she returned to the table, her sister smiled at her. Small. Proud. Noa sat down.

The old name had returned. But Noa did not. Not to it. Not to them. Not to the grave they kept mistaking for home.

Chapter 13

Noa

Some days, nothing happened. No confrontation. No old name. No room waiting to decide whether she was allowed to exist. Just morning.

Coffee. Keys. A message from Lina asking, Did you eat? Noa smiled at the screen.

Not because the question was profound, but because ordinary care still surprised her. For so long, love had arrived dressed as crisis. Correction. Concern.

Debate. Fear. Now, sometimes, it arrived as a friend asking about breakfast. She made coffee in a mug with a small chip near the handle. The apartment was not perfect.

A chair with laundry folded over it. A plant half-thriving near the window. Books stacked in places books were not supposed to live. It was not a curated life. It was hers.

That alone felt like grace. She stood in the kitchen barefoot, hair still half-wild from sleep, and listened to the kettle begin its quiet work.

There was a time when silence had frightened her. Silence meant someone was about to leave. Someone was thinking. Someone was judging. Someone was praying for the wrong person in another room.

Now, some mornings, silence simply meant nothing was attacking her. She took the coffee to the window and watched the street begin. A bus sighing at the corner.

A woman walking fast with a tote bag slipping off her shoulder. A man unlocking a shop door. Someone laughing too loudly into a phone. The world kept being ordinary even after everything that had nearly ended her.

That used to offend her. Now, it comforted her. At the café near work, the barista looked up and smiled.

"Morning, Noa."

No pause. No hesitation. No performance. Just her name passing through a normal day

as if it belonged there. Because it did. Noa ordered the same thing she always ordered and realised, halfway through paying, that her body had not flinched.

There had been no internal preparation. No brace. No quiet calculation of who might hear. Just: Morning, Noa.

And: Thank you. That was all. Sometimes healing is not a revelation. Sometimes it is the absence of the old wound for three seconds

before you even notice. At work, her name sat on the screen. Noa. Email. Calendar.

Badge. Not everywhere, not always, but enough that the day did not begin with an argument against paper. A colleague asked about a report.

Someone complained about the printer. Someone else had brought cake for no clear reason. Noa answered emails. Made a mistake in a spreadsheet. Fixed it.

Laughed when Lina sent a voice note about a disastrous date with a woman who had described herself as "spiritual" and then spent forty minutes talking about crystals and tax evasion. Noa laughed loud enough that someone looked over. For once, she did not shrink.

She let the laugh belong to her. At lunch, her sister called. Not about anything urgent. Just to ask if Noa still had the recipe for their grandmother's rice.

"She never wrote it down," Noa said.

"She measured with her ancestors."

Her sister snorted. Then there was a small silence. The safe kind.

"I miss you," her sister said.

Noa looked down at the container in front of her.

"I'm here," she answered.

"I know," her sister said.

And this time, it sounded like she did. After work, Noa walked home instead of taking the bus. The air was cool. Not cinematic. Not symbolic.

Just cool enough to make her pull her jacket closer. She passed a shop window and caught her reflection. For years, reflections had been negotiations. Arguments in glass.

Evidence for and against herself. Now, she glanced, saw a woman walking home with tired eyes and coffee on her sleeve, and kept moving. No trial.

No verdict. No need to explain. Just recognition. At home, she changed clothes, washed her face,

answered messages, forgot where she had put her keys even though they were in her hand. She ate dinner from a bowl on the couch. The rice was too soft.

The sauce was better than expected. A candle burned on the table, not as ritual, not as proof of peace, but because she liked the smell.

Later, before bed, Noa prayed. Not long. Not beautifully. No performance for heaven.

No argument with the ghosts of people who had once taught her how prayer was supposed to sound. Just:

"Thank You for today."

Then, after a pause,

"Help me live tomorrow too."

That was enough. There had been a time when every prayer felt like a negotiation for permission to exist. Now, some prayers were simply evidence

that she did. Noa turned off the light and lay in the dark. Not hiding. Resting.

There is a difference. The old name was somewhere in the world. In memories. In mouths. In files that had not yet learned to die.

But it was not in her bed. Not in her breath. Not in the small room where her life had finally begun to sound like itself. Noa was not finished healing. She still had days that cut.

Rooms that tightened. Voices that pulled her back toward fear. But not every day was a battle. Some days were proof that survival had made room for living.

Noa was not waiting to become real anymore. She was learning how to be ordinary inside the truth she had survived so much to reach.

Closing

The Woman Who Answered Herself

My name is Noa.

Not because
everyone says it.

Not because
every document
has caught up.

Not because
every person
who once loved
the old name

has learned
how to love me
without it.

My name is Noa

because I know
who I am

when no one else
is willing
to say it.

For years,
I waited
for permission.

From family.

From church.

From men.

From papers.

From rooms
that acted

as if my existence
needed approval

before it could
take up space.

I waited
for someone
to look at me
and say,

Yes.

This is true.

You may live now.

No one should have
that much power
over a soul.

I gave it
to them anyway.

I became fluent
in other people's
comfort.

I knew when
to lower my voice.

When to disappear.

When to laugh.

When to stay quiet.

When to answer
to a name

that made everyone else
feel safe

and made me
feel buried.

I called it
obedience.

I called it
wisdom.

I called it
patience.

Sometimes,
I even called it

faith.

But God
and fear

do not always
sound different

when you have been taught
to mistrust yourself.

This is what
I know now:

I am not
a revelation.

I am not
a debate.

I am not
a lesson

for frightened people
to use

when they need
a warning.

I am not
the old name.

I am not
the good lie.

I am not
the body
they argued over.

I am not
the rumor.

I am not
the shame

they tried
to make holy.

I am a woman

who survived
being called
everything

except herself.

That survival
cost me.

People.

Rooms.

Certainty.

Versions of home.

It cost me
the comfort

of being loved
incorrectly.

It cost me
the safety

of disappearing
well.

It cost me
the old applause.

But it gave me
back something

I did not know
a person could lose:

the sound
of my own life

calling me home.

Noa.

Not whispered
like a secret.

Not offered
like an apology.

Not defended
like a case.

Noa.

A name
small enough

to fit
in my mouth

and large enough
to hold

the woman
I almost abandoned.

I do not need
everyone
to understand

before I am allowed
to breathe.

I do not need
every prayer
to agree with me

before God
can meet me.

I do not need
every room
to welcome me

before I stop
calling myself
a stranger.

Some people
will keep

the old name

like a relic.

Let them.

Some people
will tell
the old story

because it asks
less of them.

Let them.

Some people
will call me
bad

because truth
made me difficult
to control.

Let them.

I have spent
too much of my life

answering
every accusation

as if my existence
were a courtroom.

It is not.

It is a life.

Mine.

And I am tired
of standing

at the door
of my own soul

waiting for people
who never planned
to let me in

to tell me
I may enter.

So this is
the vow
I make now:

I will not return
to a name

that kept me alive
only enough

to keep me useful.

I will not call
self-erasure
holiness.

I will not make
my body
a courtroom

for people
who confuse
certainty

with love.

I will not let
their fear
become
my theology.

I will not let
their grief
become
my prison.

I will not become
a good lie again

just because truth
made the room
uncomfortable.

My name is Noa.

Not because
the world
finally answered.

Because I did.

And this time,
when her life
called her by name,

Noa answered.

About the Author

Sabino Pereira writes emotionally charged fiction, poetic essays, and reflective stories about identity, love, faith, dignity, survival, and the quiet cost of being misunderstood. His work often explores people who are judged before they are known: women carrying reputations they did not fully choose, wounded lovers trying to find language for what broke them, and souls learning how to live truthfully in a world that prefers simple labels.

The Bad Girl Gospel series is part confession, part character study, and part spiritual reflection. Through stories such as *Selah*, *Diana*, and *Noa*, Sabino examines the lives of women who have been desired, moralised over, misread, rejected, and spoken about more often than they have been truly heard. He writes with a cinematic, intimate style, blending emotional realism with lyrical prose. His stories are not interested in perfect heroes or simple villains, but in the complicated human space between shame and freedom, silence and confession, survival and becoming.

Sabino Pereira is also a creator, musician, and independent author exploring books, music, and visual storytelling across different creative projects.

About the Author

Sabino Pereira creates fiction, reflective books, music, and work about behavior, healing, discernment, faith, and modern life.

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